

CHAPTER 17 — First Lesson

The cottage appeared only after the road had narrowed beyond usefulness.

Elias turned through a gap between two stone walls, followed a rutted track beneath overhanging branches and stopped at a rusted gate secured with a chain. Beyond it, the land fell away into darkness. The headlamps reached a collapsed shed, the edge of an orchard and the corner of a low stone building with ivy covering one end.

Zoe woke when the engine stopped.

She sat upright beneath Elias's old jacket and looked through the windscreen.

"This is it?"

"This is the gate."

"That wasn't the question."

"No."

He took a key from beneath the lining of his wallet.

The chain opened reluctantly. Elias drove through, closed the gate behind them and continued without lights for the final hundred metres.

Zoe noticed.

"You think someone followed us."

"I think headlights advertise."

"To who?"

"Anyone awake."

The cottage stood lower than the surrounding field, sheltered on three sides by trees and an old stone bank. Its roof sagged slightly above one upstairs window. Shutters covered the ground floor.

Nothing moved around it.

Elias parked beside a barn whose doors had warped apart at the centre.

The dashboard clock showed 1:43 a.m.

He switched off the engine.

“Stay here.”

Zoe’s hand went to the door handle.

“You said I could decide.”

“You can decide whether to stay in the car or stand behind me. You cannot walk into a building I haven’t checked.”

“That sounds like deciding for me.”

“It is.”

She stared at him.

Elias took the keys.

“This is the part where I accept that you may hate me for five minutes.”

“Only five?”

“I’m tired.”

He got out.

Zoe followed.

The night was colder than it had been at the petrol station. Wet grass brushed her ankles. Somewhere beyond the orchard, water moved over stones with the steady sound of something that had been there long before the cottage and expected to remain long after it.

Elias opened the front door and entered first.

Zoe stood outside with the backpack pressed against her ribs.

There was no sound from inside.

Then a dim torch beam moved from room to room behind the shutters.

Two minutes later Elias returned.

"No one inside. No recent footprints at the back. Dust across the unused doors. Locks are still oxidised. Pipes are cold."

"How can you smell cold pipes?"

"I didn't say I could."

"You said no one's been inside."

"Empty buildings tell on people."

"That sounds made up."

"It would be more convincing if you hadn't asked."

He stood aside.

Zoe crossed the threshold.

The cottage smelled of cold stone, old wood and fabric that had absorbed too many winters.

The front room held a fireplace, two mismatched chairs and a sofa hidden beneath a sheet. Books leaned together on shelves built into an alcove. A narrow

kitchen opened behind it, with copper pans above an old stove and a refrigerator that belonged to another decade.

Nothing matched.

Nothing looked recently chosen.

The place felt less like a home than a collection of objects a man had once believed he might need.

Elias opened a wooden cabinet beside the door and lifted an old ceramic fuse switch.

A single yellow bulb came on over the kitchen table.

Zoe looked up.

"You said no phones."

"It isn't connected to anything except wires."

"No smart meter?"

"No smart anything."

"That sounds deliberate."

"It became useful later."

He opened the water valve beneath the sink.

Brown water coughed into the basin, cleared slowly and became transparent.

"When did you last come here?" Zoe asked.

"Years."

"How many?"

"Enough that the taps need running."

"Why keep it?"

He watched the water.

"I didn't know where else to put it."

"The cottage?"

"Myself."

Zoe looked at him.

He reached for a kettle before she could ask another question.

"The upstairs bedroom has a lock on the inside," he said. "The key is in the door."

"Where are you sleeping?"

"Down here."

"There are two bedrooms."

"The other one has part of the ceiling in it."

"That seems inconvenient."

"It wasn't planned."

He filled the kettle.

Zoe remained beside the table.

"Can anyone open my bedroom from outside?"

"No."

"Do you have another key?"

"No."

"How do I know?"

"You don't."

The answer made more sense to her than reassurance would have.

"You can wedge the chair beneath the handle if you prefer," Elias said.

"I know."

"I assumed you would."

She looked towards the stairs.

"What happens if someone comes?"

"I wake you."

"And if you can't?"

He considered the house.

"Bedroom window. There's a lean-to roof directly beneath it. Get onto that, stay low and move to the lower edge. The water barrel is underneath. From the barrel to the ground is about four feet. Then go through the orchard. Do not use the track."

Zoe pictured it.

"And if the barrel isn't there?"

"It is."

"You checked."

"Yes."

She nodded once.

A route mattered more than reassurance.

Elias opened a cupboard and found tea sealed inside an old metal tin. The date on the packet had passed three years earlier.

"Is that safe?" Zoe asked.

"It's tea."

"That wasn't the question."

He examined the packet.

"We have water."

"Good decision."

He put it back.

They ate bread and hummus at the kitchen table beneath the single yellow bulb. Zoe finished two pieces before realising how hungry she had become.

Elias did not mention it.

Twenty minutes later, she carried the backpack upstairs.

A few minutes after that, the chair scraped across the bedroom floor and settled beneath the handle.

Downstairs, Elias turned off the light.

Zoe lay awake long enough to hear him move once through the front room, then not again.

She woke to birds.

Not silence.

Birds.

Wind moved through leaves outside the bedroom window. Water continued over stones. Something tapped against the glass, stopped, then tapped again.

For several seconds she did not know where she was.

The chair beneath the handle reminded her.

She checked the backpack first.

Folder.

Hard drive.

Clothes.

Photograph.

All present.

The room contained a narrow bed, a wardrobe that smelled of cedar and a small table beneath the window. Sheets Elias had found folded in a cupboard downstairs were clean enough to use after being shaken outside, though one still carried the faint outline of a dead moth.

Zoe removed the chair.

The cottage was empty.

A note lay on the kitchen table beneath the packet of biscuits.

Outside. Do not leave the house. Back door unlocked.

She read it twice.

Then she opened the back door and found Elias lying beneath the hatchback.

Only his boots and the lower half of his legs were visible.

Zoe stepped onto the threshold.

The morning was grey and damp. In daylight the cottage looked older, smaller and less secret than it had at night. The barn leaned towards it.

Beyond the orchard, the track curved between trees before disappearing uphill.

“What are you doing?”

Elias’s boots shifted.

“Checking the car.”

“For what?”

He slid out far enough to look at her.

“You were told not to leave the house.”

“I’m touching the doorstep.”

“You’re outside.”

“The door opens over this stone. It is structurally part of the house.”

Elias disappeared beneath the car again.

“That argument would concern me more if I had slept.”

Zoe sat on the doorstep.

A metal tool clicked against something beneath the rear quarter.

Then stopped.

Elias did not move for several seconds.

“What is it?”

He extended one hand.

“Torch.”

It lay beside the rear wheel.

Zoe picked it up and placed it in his palm.

The beam moved beneath the car.

Elias reached higher, felt along an unseen edge and withdrew his hand.

Black adhesive marked his fingertips.

He came out fully and crouched beside the wheel.

“What?”

He looked towards the track.

Then at the cottage.

Then back beneath the car.

Zoe stood.

“What did you find?”

Elias removed a small folding knife from his pocket and cut through a strip of black material fixed behind the plastic lining. He worked carefully, using the torch only when his hand blocked the daylight.

A rectangular device came free.

It was smaller than Zoe expected.

Black casing. Sealed edges. A green light no larger than a pinhead.

It pulsed once.

Zoe stepped backwards.

“That’s the tracker.”

Elias turned it over.

No markings.

No manufacturer.

A magnetic plate had been reinforced with adhesive and fixed behind the rear quarter where road dirt had already begun to cover it.

“Recent,” he said.

“How recent?”

He touched the edge of the mounting strip.

“Clean adhesive under the lip. Fresh tool marks on the liner.”

“When?”

“The service yard.”

“The heat-shield repair.”

“Yes.”

Mac’s mechanic had supposedly corrected the loose heat shield two days earlier.

Zoe looked towards the cottage.

“So he knows where we are.”

“He knows where this last reported.”

“That is here.”

“Maybe.”

“Maybe?”

“The valley has almost no signal. It may have stopped transmitting before we reached the cottage. It may also have stored later positions and sent them when it found service again.”

“That is two versions of bad.”

“Three, if it transmitted everything.”

The green light pulsed again.

Elias unfolded the knife and worked the casing open.

Inside, a battery sat beneath a small circuit board.

Zoe watched the track.

“You said nobody knew this place existed.”

“Nobody I knew about.”

“Mac does now.”

"Maybe the valley. Maybe the upper road. Maybe this property."

"That is not better."

"No."

He disconnected the battery.

The green light died.

Zoe stared at the black casing.

"He expected you to disobey."

"He planned for the possibility."

"He didn't trust you."

"No."

"He sent me with someone he didn't trust and tracked both of us."

Elias placed the battery in one coat pocket and the device in another.

"He trusted the system around us."

Zoe looked at the car.

At the cottage.

At the track they had taken in darkness.

They had not been discovered through betrayal or luck.

They had brought the problem with them.

"What do we do?"

"I check the ridge and the road. Work out where the signal disappears. Then we decide how much of the valley they can realistically narrow down."

"You said we were sleeping."

"You slept."

"You didn't."

"That was not part of the agreement."

Zoe folded her arms.

"You also said I chose the cottage."

"You did."

"From options you gave me."

"Yes."

"And one option came with a tracker."

"The car came with the tracker."

"We were in the car."

Elias took the accusation without trying to escape it.

"I should have found it sooner."

Zoe had expected explanation.

The admission displaced some of her anger and left nowhere obvious to put it.

"You didn't know."

"I should have checked after the service yard."

"Why didn't you?"

Elias looked at the dead device in his pocket.

"Because I thought I understood the limits of how Mac controlled people."

"You knew he controlled people."

"Yes."

"And you worked for him."

"Yes."

"That is worse than not knowing."

"Yes."

The stream continued beyond the trees.

Elias stood.

"We are not leaving exhausted. That creates a different kind of mistake. I'll check the ridge and the road. You stay inside."

"For how long?"

"An hour."

"What if you don't come back?"

"Wait another hour. Then take the backpack, leave through the bedroom window and go through the orchard. Follow the stream downhill. It meets a public footpath. Nearest village is about three miles east."

"Where is east?"

He pointed.

"Sunrise side."

"It's cloudy."

"The stream."

"That is better."

Inside, he drew a rough map on the back of the expired tea packet.

Then he pulled a short coil of thin utility rope from a cupboard beneath the stairs.

"What is that?"

"For the backpack."

He tied one end to the bedframe upstairs and fed the rest beneath the window.

"If you have to leave through there, lower the bag first. Do not jump with it."

Zoe looked at him.

"You planned that quickly."

"I planned the first thirty seconds. After that, you improvise."

He left by the back door.

Zoe locked it behind him.

He returned a little over an hour later.

Mud marked his boots to the ankles.

Zoe had moved the kitchen chair so she could see both the back door and the front window without standing directly in either.

Elias noticed.

He said nothing about it.

"Well?" she asked.

"Coverage dies below the ridge. One weak network up there. Nothing useful here."

"So the tracker stopped before the cottage."

"My best guess is the last clean transmission happened somewhere below the upper track."

"Best guess."

"Yes."

"You don't know."

"No."

"Good."

Elias looked at her.

"Good?"

"You keep saying when you don't know."

He removed his coat and placed it over a chair.

"Anyone following the last clean position can probably identify the valley. Maybe the upper track. I don't think they have this front door from the signal alone."

"From the signal alone."

"Yes."

"And if it stored the route?"

"Then it could report more when it reconnects."

"So we keep it dead."

"Yes."

He tapped the pocket containing the separated device.

"Leaving it here would confirm the cottage. Taking it gives us one more decision later."

Zoe sat at the kitchen table. The backpack remained closed beside her feet.

"How long until someone comes?"

"Depends when Mac decided this was a recovery rather than an argument."

"You know he hired someone."

"I know Mac doesn't leave his desk to solve problems."

"Who?"

"I don't know."

"Cain?"

"Could be. But nothing at the service station looked coordinated."

"So Mac is hunting us separately."

"That's my working assumption."

"Two groups."

"At least two interests. Maybe two teams."

"You really don't know much."

"I know enough to avoid pretending they're one problem."

He put a saucepan on the stove.

"What are you doing?"

"Breakfast."

"We have people hunting us."

"We also have beans."

"That is not a strategy."

"It is the part before strategy."

He opened a tin.

Zoe watched him pour the beans into the pan.

"Are we leaving?"

"Not today."

She stared at him.

"They have the area."

"They have an area large enough to waste time in. If we move now, exhausted, we create a fresh trail while they are actively searching."

"So we stay inside the place they are looking for."

"We stay quiet. No phones. No car. No lights after dark. We learn what normal traffic looks like before we decide what is abnormal."

"You're using the cottage as bait."

"No. I'm refusing to run every time someone moves a piece."

"That sounds like something the Reaper would say."

Elias stirred the beans.

"Jackie's story has made him much more talkative than he ever was."

"You mean you."

"I mean breakfast."

He divided the beans between two bowls.

The answer ended the conversation without winning it.

Before they ate, Elias rolled the hatchback into the barn.

The warped doors would not close fully, but from the road only a narrow section of dark bodywork remained visible through the gap.

Zoe watched him wedge one door with a length of timber.

"Better?"

"Less obvious."

"That is not the same."

"No."

She carried the bowls inside.

Tuesday passed without engines on the track.

That became its own kind of pressure.

Elias walked the property boundary twice, using the trees rather than the path. He checked the windows, roofline and old cellar beneath the kitchen. He found paraffin, blankets, two working torches, a box of candles and a radio whose batteries had corroded into white powder.

Zoe cleaned one shelf in the kitchen and declared the rest biologically independent.

They ate bread, beans, apples and the expensive hummus she had chosen at the petrol station.

The old electrical supply remained on only long enough to run the kettle and refrigerator. No networked meter, no digital thermostat, no

router,

nothing that could announce occupancy more efficiently than light through a window.

Elias slept for three hours in the afternoon.

Zoe noticed because he stopped responding to the sounds of the house.

She stood in the doorway to the front room and watched him in the chair beneath the window. His head had fallen against one side. One arm rested close to his coat pocket. Even asleep, he had positioned himself between the stairs and the front door.

She pulled the old jacket from the back of another chair and carried it towards him.

His hand closed around her wrist before the fabric touched his shoulder.

Fast.

Zoe froze.

Elias released her immediately and pushed himself upright.

For one second, his eyes did not belong to the cottage.

Then they did.

"I was giving it back," Zoe said.

He looked at the jacket in her other hand.

"Bad idea."

"I noticed."

"I'm sorry."

"You didn't hurt me."

"That isn't the measure."

She rubbed her wrist, although it did not need rubbing.

Elias stood and moved away from the chair.

“Wake me from across the room next time.”

“There won’t be a next time.”

“Fair.”

She placed the jacket on the sofa.

“Do you always sleep like that?”

“No.”

“You are lying.”

“Yes.”

It was the first lie he had admitted quickly enough to become almost a joke.

Almost.

That evening Elias made a fire small enough to produce little smoke. Zoe found a deck of cards in a kitchen drawer with eleven cards missing.

They attempted a game neither of them could complete according to the rules.

Elias accused the former owner of cheating.

“You are the former owner.”

“That explains it.”

For twenty minutes, the tracker did not exist.

Neither did Mac, Cain, Jackie, the folder or the people somewhere beyond the valley trying to work out which road mattered.

The cottage held firelight, bad cards and two people eating biscuits they had both pretended not to want.

Temporary safety was still safety.

Zoe slept for nine hours.

Wednesday morning arrived bright and cold.

Elias was at the edge of the orchard when Zoe came downstairs. This time he had left no note because she could see him through the kitchen window.

She made tea using fresh packets discovered behind a jar of salt. It tasted faintly of the cupboard.

When Elias returned, she placed a mug in front of him.

He drank it without checking the date.

"You're improving," she said.

"At tea?"

"At trusting dangerous substances."

He looked into the mug.

"I thought you wanted to learn something useful."

Zoe stopped. "What?"

"You asked yesterday how to tell normal traffic from abnormal."

"I asked when we were leaving."

"You asked both."

"That is not the same."

"No."

She sat opposite him. "With what?"

"Observation."

"Not fighting?"

"Especially not fighting."

"I didn't ask to fight."

"You were going to."

"I was deciding."

"You decide loudly."

Zoe took her mug. "Fine. Teach me something useful."

Elias pointed towards the shuttered front window. "Tell me what is outside."

"A track."

"What else?"

"Trees. Gate. Stone wall. Mud. Post box without a door."

"That is description."

"You asked what is outside."

"I asked what is happening outside."

"That is a different question."

"It is the useful one."

He opened the shutter by two inches.

"People notice objects. What matters is pattern. Who belongs. What repeats. What changes."

"Cars."

"Sometimes. Also sound. Animals. Curtains. Smoke. A gate left open that was closed before. A dog that barks at everybody except one person."

Zoe looked through the gap.

The cottage did not overlook the public road directly. From the front window she could see the track descending past the orchard and, through a break in the trees, a narrow slice of road near the valley

entrance. Vehicles appeared for only a few seconds before the stone bank concealed them.

"You can't see enough."

"That is the lesson."

"That seems badly designed."

"Danger rarely agrees to pass slowly in front of a large window."

He moved away.

"For one hour, you watch. No notebook. At the end tell me what passed, which direction, approximate speed and anything that did not fit."

"Why no notebook?"

"Because looking down costs time."

"I could write without looking."

"Then you would remember the writing instead of the event."

She considered arguing.

Instead she took the chair by the window.

"What are you doing?"

"Checking the back boundary."

"So you aren't watching."

"No."

"You'll have to believe me."

"That is also the lesson."

He left the room.

For the first fifteen minutes, nothing happened.

Zoe listened to the clock above the fireplace and the water beyond the orchard.

A tractor appeared through the trees, moving towards the upper fields. Its engine reached the cottage before the vehicle did.

Red body.

Mud along the wheels.

Driver in a green cap.

No passenger.

Seven minutes later it returned without the trailer it had been pulling.

A small blue car passed downhill quickly. The driver did not turn his head.

A postal van stopped near the first property on the track, reversed badly and left.

Two walkers appeared near the gate with a white dog. The dog pulled towards the orchard until one of them shortened its lead.

Zoe held the details in order.

Tractor up.

Tractor down.

Blue car.

Post van.

Walkers.

Dog.

At forty-one minutes, a grey estate car entered the visible slice of road.

It moved slowly enough that Zoe first thought it was turning towards the track.

It did not.

The car continued past.

Cream interior.

Dark object hanging beneath the mirror.

Driver alone.

Right hand high on the wheel.

The driver kept his face forward so carefully that the effort itself

looked wrong.

Everyone else had looked somewhere.

Road.

Gate.

Dog.

Post box.

Turning.

This man looked nowhere.

Three minutes later, the estate car returned from the opposite direction.

This time it passed faster.

As it cleared the entrance, the driver's eyes moved to the rear-view mirror.

His head did not turn.

The car disappeared.

Zoe rose from the chair.

Elias had said one hour.

Fifty-four minutes had passed.

She remained at the window.

At fifty-eight minutes, the red tractor returned with its trailer.

At sixty, Elias entered through the kitchen.

"Well?"

"Six vehicles if repeats count separately. Four if they don't. Two walkers and a dog."

He leaned against the doorway.

"Order."

She gave it to him.

He asked about the tractor.

She described the missing trailer.

The blue car.

Direction and speed.

Postal van.

Walkers.

Then the estate car.

"Grey. Older model. Cream interior. Something dark hanging beneath the mirror. It passed uphill slowly, then came back three minutes later faster."

"Driver?"

"One man. He didn't look at the track the first time."

"That alone doesn't mean anything."

"He didn't look anywhere."

Elias's attention changed.

"Second pass?"

"He watched the entrance in the mirror after he went by."

"Did he slow?"

"No."

"Number plate?"

"Too dirty. Last two might have been seven and K. Or seven and X."

"Rear window?"

"A pale rectangle in the lower corner. Old permit maybe."

"How old was the driver?"

"Forty. Maybe older. Short hair. Dark coat."

"Did he see you?"

"No."

"How do you know?"

"The shutters were closed except for the gap. The glass reflected the room behind me, not me."

Elias crossed to the window.

The road was empty.

"He came twice," Zoe said.

"Yes."

"You know the car."

"No."

"You believe me."

"Yes."

The speed of the answer made her watch him more carefully.

Elias closed the shutter.

"What happens now?"

"We leave tomorrow before first light."

"Why not now?"

"My best read is the first pass was search. The second checked the access road. That does not mean they have this cottage."

"You said patterns."

"Yes."

"What is the pattern?"

"They'll widen out. Compare access roads, fuel, cameras, houses that look empty. Eventually somebody comes closer."

"How long?"

"Not long enough to stay."

Zoe looked towards the backpack beside the stairs.

"Was that Mac's team?"

"Possibly."

"Cain's?"

"Possibly."

"You really don't know anything."

"I know the driver was unlikely to be local."

"Because of the car?"

"A local is less likely to need two passes to decide whether this road goes anywhere."

He opened the cupboard beneath the stairs and removed an old canvas holdall.

Zoe watched him.

"That was the lesson?"

"That was the first one."

"I found them."

"Yes."

"You would have seen the car anyway."

"Maybe."

"Would you?"

He looked at her.

"No."

Elias gave her exactly what she had asked for: the truth.

Zoe glanced at the closed shutter.

"What did I do right?"

"You noticed absence. He was trying not to look interested. Most people remember the slow car. You remembered the behaviour."

"And the mirror."

"And the mirror."

She absorbed that.

"Does that mean you'll teach me more?"

Elias placed food, candles and the road atlas into the holdall.

"It means next time you watch for what changes after they think nobody noticed them."

"That sounds like yes."

"It sounds like packing."

Zoe went upstairs.

At the bedroom door, she stopped.

"Where are we going?"

"A farmhouse."

"Yours?"

"No."

"Who knows about it?"

"Fewer people than know this cottage."

"That is not the same as nobody."

Elias looked towards the wall, beyond it to the track and the road

where the estate car had passed twice.

"No," he said. "We're finished using that word."

That night, Elias kept the fire dark.

Zoe slept upstairs in her clothes with the backpack against the bed and the chair beneath the handle.

Downstairs, the cottage contracted as the temperature fell.

Wood clicked.

Pipes settled.

Water moved over stones.

At 2:17 a.m., Elias heard an engine somewhere near the valley entrance.

He remained still.

No headlights reached the cottage.

No doors closed.

The engine idled for roughly four minutes, then moved away.

He did not wake Zoe.

A vehicle stopping in a valley was not proof.

Waking her would turn uncertainty into panic before he had anything useful to add.

He waited another hour.

Nothing returned.

At 4:30, he went upstairs.

"Zoe."

She woke immediately.

No confusion this time.

“What?”

“We’re moving.”

She reached for the backpack before sitting up.

By five, they had removed the obvious signs of recent occupation.

Fresh rubbish went into the holdall.

Sheets were stripped.

Food was packed.

The fire had been dead for hours; Elias broke up the ashes and restored the grate as closely as he could to how he had found it.

They did not pretend they could erase themselves.

They only removed the easiest proof of when they had been there.

The tracker remained separated from its battery inside Elias’s coat.

He was not leaving it behind.

Leaving it at the cottage would turn uncertainty into confirmation.

Taking it gave him one more choice.

Before they left, Zoe stood at the back door with the cottage key in her hand.

“Are we coming back?”

“Not soon.”

She looked into the kitchen.

Mismatched chairs.

Incomplete cards.

Expired tea.

The shelf she had cleaned because apparently one shelf was enough civilisation for a Tuesday.

A refuge did not need to last to have been real.

She held out the key.

Elias opened his hand.

She placed it in his palm.

He locked the back door behind them.

They walked through the orchard rather than towards the track.

The hatchback remained inside the barn.

Beyond the stream, beneath a canvas cover in a stand of trees, another vehicle waited.

Older.

Darker.

Lower than the hatchback.

Zoe stopped beside it.

"You have another car."

"I have several bad decisions stored in different places."

He pulled the canvas free.

The car belonged to the same dormant identity as the cottage. Unlike the cottage, it had not been abandoned to weather. Once a year, through a storage arrangement that required neither conversation nor Elias's presence, it was serviced, taxed and returned to the same place with a fresh battery.

He had kept paying for it long after he stopped believing he would ever need it.

That now seemed less foolish than it had a week earlier. Zoe looked through the driver's window. "Does it work?" "It did six months ago."

"That is not encouraging."

"It is better than twelve years."

She crouched beside the rear wheel. "Does this one have a tracker?"

"We're about to find out."

For the first time since the estate car passed the valley entrance, she smiled. Only briefly. Elias handed her the torch. "Same rule," he said.

"Assume nothing because you own it."

They began the sweep together.